Canadian Scam Intelligence Brief

Data through 2025-09 · CAFC Fraud Reporting System + 83 CAFC bulletins · Prepared October 22, 2026 · Independent analysis of public data

Investment and crypto scams now drive 54% of reported fraud losses ($151M in six months, +26% year-over-year), with median victim loss climbing to $32K. Recovery pitches surged +336% in losses, re-victimizing the same cohort.

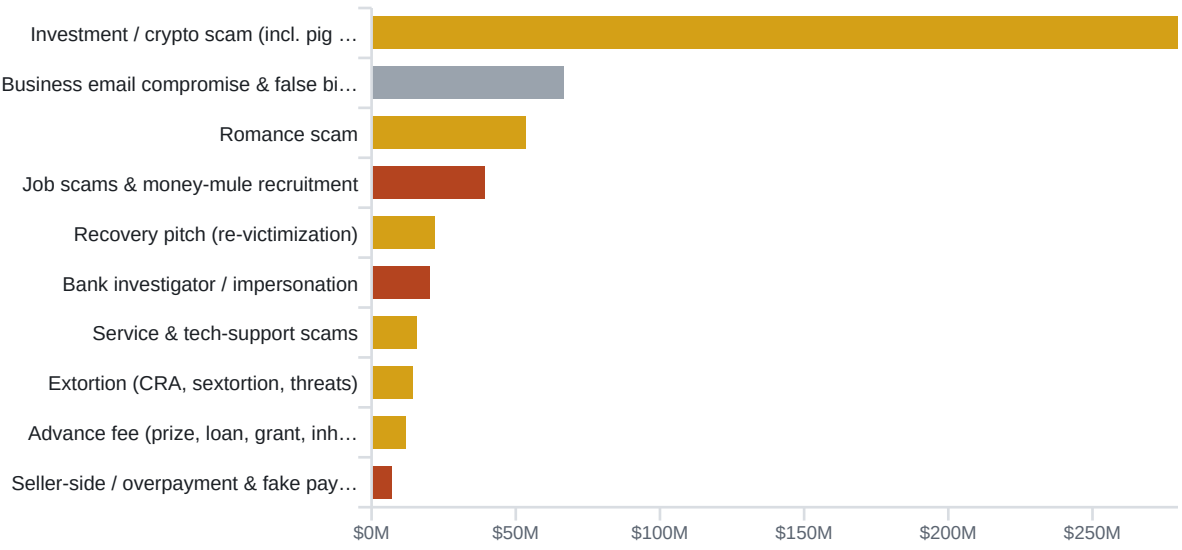
Reports (12 mo)	Victim reports	Reported losses	Losses: victims 60+
37,102	**26,321**	**$564M**	**37%**

Period: 2024-10 to 2025-09.

Key judgements

- Investment and crypto scams accounted for $151M in losses over six months, 54% of all reported fraud losses, with median loss per victim rising from $25K to $32K.
- Recovery pitch losses jumped +336% year-over-year to $16M, with median loss climbing from $7,550 to $17,575—suggesting scammers are systematically re-targeting prior victims.
- Seniors lost 52% of investment scam dollars and 55% of recovery pitch losses, indicating concentrated exposure in this demographic.
- Text message contact share rose 2.2 percentage points while direct calls fell 1.0 point, suggesting fraudsters are shifting to asynchronous channels that evade real-time intervention.

Where reported losses concentrate (last 12 months)



Bar colour = bank-transfer exposure: High Medium Low. An analyst judgement of how often the scam's money moves by bank transfer (e-Transfer, debit, EFT), where banks and payment networks can intervene, rather than by crypto, gift cards or cash.

How victims are told to pay (share of 83 bulletins naming each method)

Wire / money service	Cryptocurrency	Gift cards	Bank transfer	Card	Cash
32%	**31%**	**12%**	**12%**	**11%**	**10%**

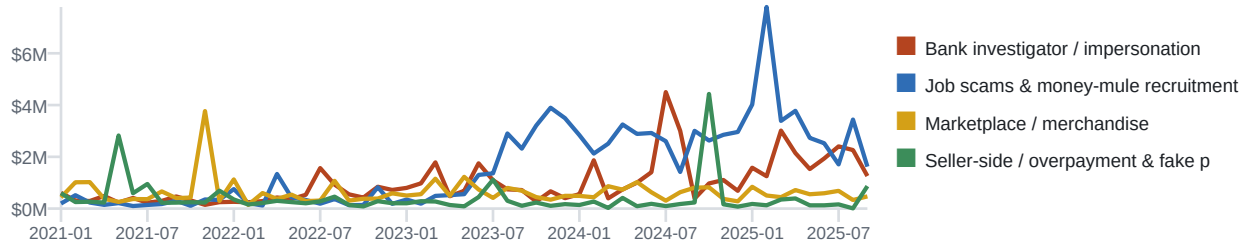
A bulletin can name several methods. Bulletins describe how scams work, not how often each method is used.

What's growing: 2025-04 to 2025-09 vs 2024-04 to 2024-09 (same months a year earlier)

Typology	Usually paid via	Reports	Rpts YoY	Losses	Losses YoY	Median loss	60+ share
Investment / crypto scam (incl. pig butchering)	Crypto, Wire	1,592	-4%	$151.4M	**+26%**	$32.0K	52%
Business email compromise & false billing	Wire, Bank transfer	445	-29%	$31.5M	+13%	$38.0K	4%
Romance scam	Crypto, Wire	368	-14%	$26.0M	**+26%**	$30.0K	48%
Job scams & money-mule recruitment	Crypto, Wire	759	-22%	$15.8M	-2%	$14.2K	11%
Recovery pitch (re-victimization)	Wire, Crypto	486	+50%	$15.6M	**+336%**	$17.6K	55%
Bank investigator / impersonation	Wire, Crypto	899	-37%	$11.5M	+4%	$10.0K	37%
Advance fee (prize, loan, grant, inheritance)	Wire, Crypto	430	-25%	$7.9M	**+26%**	$2.4K	36%
Extortion (CRA, sextortion, threats)	Crypto, Wire	833	-37%	$7.1M	-3%	$6.0K	13%
Service & tech-support scams	Wire, Bank transfer	1,307	-41%	$6.5M	-27%	$1.5K	31%
Marketplace / merchandise (non-delivery)	Wire, Bank transfer	936	-37%	$3.4M	-19%	$0.3K	15%
Seller-side / overpayment & fake payment notice	Wire, Bank transfer	180	-43%	$1.7M	+40%*	$1.4K	54%
Emergency / grandparent scam	Cash, Crypto	219	-54%	$1.0M	-25%	$3.0K	59%
Charity, psychic & other	Gift cards, Wire	27	-50%	$0.3M	-26%	$2.0K	40%
Identity fraud (new accounts / loans in victim's name)	Card, Gift cards	3,975	-16%	$0.0M	n/a	n/a	n/a
Phishing → account takeover	Wire, Crypto	2,517	-8%	$0.0M	n/a	n/a	n/a

Highlighted rows: loss growth of 20%+ that still holds after removing each period's 3 largest reports. * = growth driven by a few very large reports; treat with caution. Report counts are falling across almost all categories as overall CAFC volumes decline, so median loss and mix are the better signals.

Monthly reported losses: largest scams with high bank-transfer exposure



How scammers make contact	Share now	vs year ago
Direct call	34%	-1.0 pts
Internet-social network	20%	+0.9 pts
Email	15%	-0.5 pts
Internet	14%	-1.6 pts
Text message	12%	+2.2 pts
Door to door/in person	3%	-0.6 pts

Watch list (from bulletins)

• Deepfakes and AI voice cloning appeared in 6 recent bulletins and could amplify bank investigator impersonation (899 reports, $12M) and emergency scams by making spoofed authority figures more convincing.

• One-time passcode theft tactics featured in 4 bulletins and directly enable phishing-to-account-takeover (2,517 reports) and bank impersonation schemes.

• Fake payment notifications via email or text (1 bulletin) could expand seller-side overpayment fraud, which saw +40% loss growth despite fewer reports.

The Payment Scam Kill Chain: where each scam can be broken

Contact → **Pretext** → **Payment request** → **Fund movement** → **Cash-out**. Each scam passes through these stages; a control at any stage breaks the chain. Controls nearer the payment stage are where a payments network has the most direct leverage.

Typology	Contact	Pretext	Payment request	Fund movement	Cash-out
Investment / crypto scam (incl. pig butchering)	• Takedown pipeline for deepfake investment ads with platforms		• Risk flag on repeated escalating transfers to crypto on-ramps		• Faster freeze/recall coordination with Canadian crypto exchanges
Business email compromise & false billing			• Payee-name check when supplier banking details change		
Romance scam		• Dating-platform warnings when users move conversation off-platform	• Pattern flag: repeated sends to one new payee with escalating amounts		
Job scams & money-mule recruitment	• Campus / youth awareness: 'if a job pays you to move money, you are the mule'			• Mule-behaviour detection: new accounts that receive and immediately forward funds	
Recovery pitch (re-victimization)	• Proactive outreach to known victims warning about recovery scams				
Bank investigator / impersonation	• Telco caller-ID authentication + bank number spoof blocking		• Scam-specific in-flow warning when a first-time payee is added shortly after an inbound call ('Your bank will never ask you to move money')	• Shared mule-account signals across institutions on the receiving side	
Advance fee (prize, loan, grant, inheritance)		• Awareness: legitimate lenders and prizes never require an up-front fee			
Extortion (CRA, sextortion, threats)		• Targeted awareness for newcomers and teens ('CRA never demands payment by e-Transfer, gift card or bitcoin')	• Retailer gift-card purchase limits and point-of-sale warnings		
Service & tech-support scams			• Detect remote-access software active during a banking session		

Typology	Contact	Pretext	Payment request	Fund movement	Cash-out
Marketplace / merchandise (non-delivery)			• Recipient-name display / confirmation before sending to a new payee	• Velocity signals on recipient accounts receiving many first-time payments	
Seller-side / overpayment & fake payment notice	• Brand-impersonation email/domain takedowns for fake payment notices	• Consumer education: real e-Transfers are deposited through your own bank app, never via an emailed link			
Emergency / grandparent scam		• Family 'safe word' public awareness campaigns aimed at seniors	• Branch / ATM teller scripts for large unusual cash withdrawals by seniors		
Identity fraud (new accounts / loans in victim's name)				• Stronger digital identity verification at account opening to cut synthetic/mule accounts	
Phishing → account takeover	• Brand-impersonation on smishing/phishing takedown service		• Step-up authentication when a new device adds a payee and sends within minutes		

Recommendations

#	Recommendation	Stage	Effort	Cost	Impact
1	**Risk flag on repeated escalating transfers to crypto on-ramps** (Investment / crypto scam (incl. pig butchering); owner: FIs) Investment and crypto scams generated $151M in six months with robust +26% loss growth and median victim loss at $32K; flagging repeated escalating transfers to crypto on-ramps targets the payment method cited in 15 bulletins and addresses the typology's medium bank-transfer exposure before losses crystallize.	Payment request	Med	Med	High
2	**Proactive outreach to known victims warning about recovery scams** (Recovery pitch (re-victimization); owner: FIs / police) Recovery pitch losses exploded +336% to $16M with median loss more than doubling to $17,575, and 55% of losses hit seniors; proactive outreach to known victims is low-effort and directly interrupts re-victimization at first contact, when intervention is cheapest.	Contact	Low	Low	Med
3	**Campus / youth awareness: 'if a job pays you to move money, you are the mule'** (Job scams & money-mule recruitment; owner: Network / schools) Job scams recorded $16M in losses with high bank-transfer exposure (cited in 3 bulletins) and 11% senior loss share, suggesting younger victims; campus awareness campaigns are low-cost and target the demographic most likely to encounter fake job offers before they become money mules.	Contact	Low	Low	Med

Method and caveats. Trends use the CAFC Fraud Reporting System open dataset (Canada only); the CAFC estimates only a small fraction of fraud is reported, so figures show direction and mix, not totals. Recent months may rise as late reports arrive. Typology mapping, bank-transfer exposure and effort/cost/impact scores are analyst judgements, documented in the project's taxonomy file. Recommendations are ranked by (impact ÷ effort+cost) × exposure × √loss share × growth. Bulletin facts were extracted with Claude and link back to source pages. Control ideas are candidates for discussion, not claims about current practice.